

5.

STOP THE SENTENCE

**DO NOT FINISH
THE SENTENCE
BEFORE REALITY DOES.**

I have started noticing that some of the most consequential things I believe about my life are hiding after commas.

This is inconvenient because commas seem innocent. Nobody has ever warned you about a comma. We have rules about semicolons, strong opinions about the Oxford comma, and an entire educational system apparently committed to making sure nobody enjoys a run-on sentence. But nobody ever pulled me aside and said, “Just so you know,



somewhere around forty you may discover that half your suffering is occurring in a dependent clause.”

And yet here we are. He hasn’t called me, so he doesn’t want to talk to me. I didn’t get the job, which means I’m back where I started. My son is struggling again, and he’s never going to get his life together. The money is getting low, so I’m going to run out. She sounded strange on the phone, which means something is wrong. These sentences move so naturally that it can be difficult to see where anything happened. The first half presents a fact.

The second half appears to finish the thought. Grammatically, it does. Epistemically, it may have just driven through a guardrail.

This is one of the simplest things I have learned to do, and I almost resent how useful it is: stop the sentence. Not forever. I have a strong preference for useful things to look as though they took more trouble than this.

We are not banning conjunctions. Just stop long enough to notice what you actually had before the sentence started helping. He hasn’t called me. Stop there for a second. What does that establish?

He hasn't called me. I know. Deeply unsatisfying. We were hoping for more.

But there is another possibility I had missed. Sometimes the speaker has already stopped the sentence internally. He has noticed the observation, separated it from the inference, considered the pattern, and decided what he is going to do.

He does not necessarily narrate every step aloud. You hear the sentence that survived the work; you do not hear everything he considered and left out. A comma can conceal an overreach; it can also conceal work. I need to find out which before I start arresting the punctuation.

Maybe I know when he usually calls. Maybe I know that he said he would call. Maybe he has been avoiding me for a week. Maybe this is the fourth time he has failed to do something he explicitly promised to do. All of that belongs if it is true.

We are not stripping the situation down until it becomes meaningless. We are stripping away only the part that arrived without evidence. If four broken promises are in the record, they stay in the record. Precision does not mean making the situation so small that nobody can be held responsible for anything.